

What India spends on libraries

A decade of per-capita expenditure analysis (2014–2025)

The Right to Read Campaign

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Right to Read · The Data Per Capita Public Library Spend · 2014–2025

WHAT INDIA SPENDS ON PUBLIC LIBRARIES.

Kulkarni, Balaji & Dhanamjaya (2025) put the number at **11.62 per Indian per year** (nominal) for 2018-19 — the highest point on record. We re-ran their analysis with the government’s own annual population projections (TG 2020) and the MoSPI implicit GDP deflator (NAS, base 2011-12). After those two corrections, and after extrapolating state-level CAG accounts through 2024-25, the real story is this:

India · 2024-25 · real terms (2011-12) 4.66

per Indian, per year, on every public library in the country. Less than a local bus ticket. Less than what the State spends on a single one of its statue commissions. Lower than 2014-15.

Section 1 · the arc

Between 2014-15 and 2018-19, state expenditure on public libraries (budget head MH 2205-105) nearly doubled in nominal terms. Adjusted with the MoSPI implicit GDP deflator (base 2011-12), the real-terms gain was modest but real: from **4.16** to **7.87** per Indian per year. From 2019-20 onwards, the line bends down — and according to the trend in the underlying CAG accounts, it has not bent back up. **By 2024-25, almost all the post-2014 real-terms gain has retreated.**

Section 2 · the spread

31 states and UTs across nearly four orders of magnitude. Jharkhand at one end. Goa at the other. The bottom half clusters near zero; the top is stretched thin. Read the strip below before the regional breakdown — and the two phenomena that distort everything that follows.

The Cess Paradox

Five states wrote library *cess* into their Public Libraries Acts — a small statutory levy, ring-fenced for libraries outside the annual budget. **Tamil Nadu’s line is steady. The other four are not.**

Section 3 · THE STATE’S OWN MAP.

In 1956, Nehru proposed grouping the reorganised states into Zonal Councils. **These are the State’s own regional categories.** Read the library line against them and the picture sharpens.

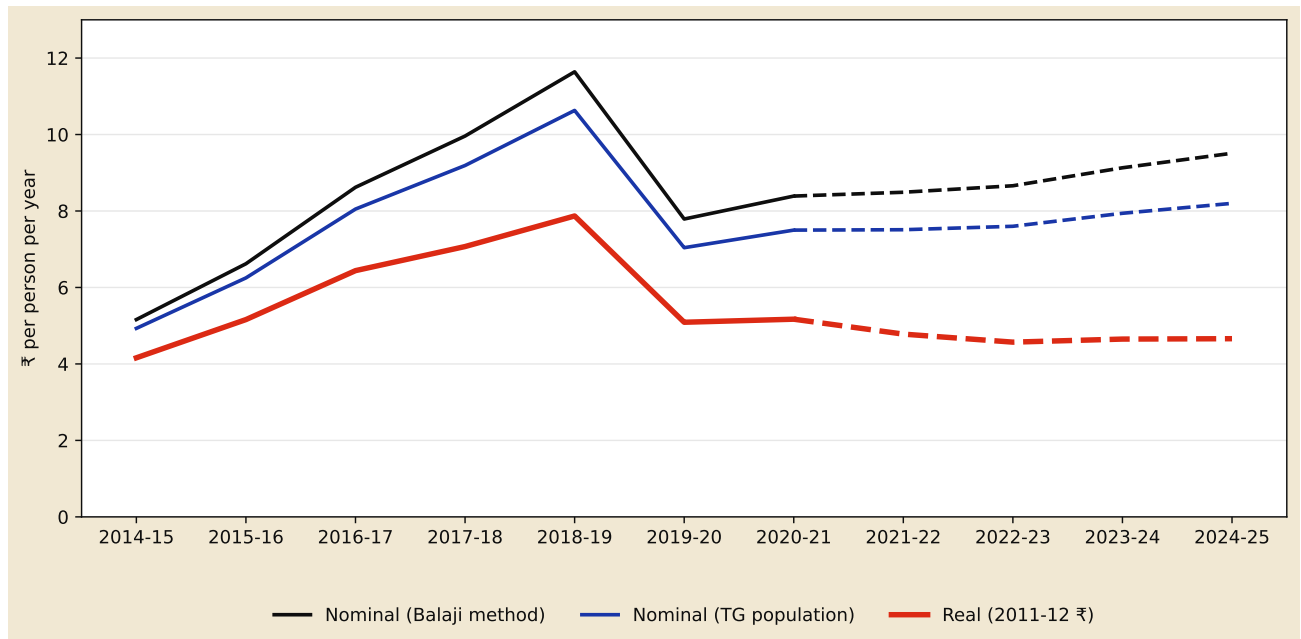


Figure 1: National per capita expenditure on public libraries. Solid = CAG Actuals. Dashed = Extrapolation.

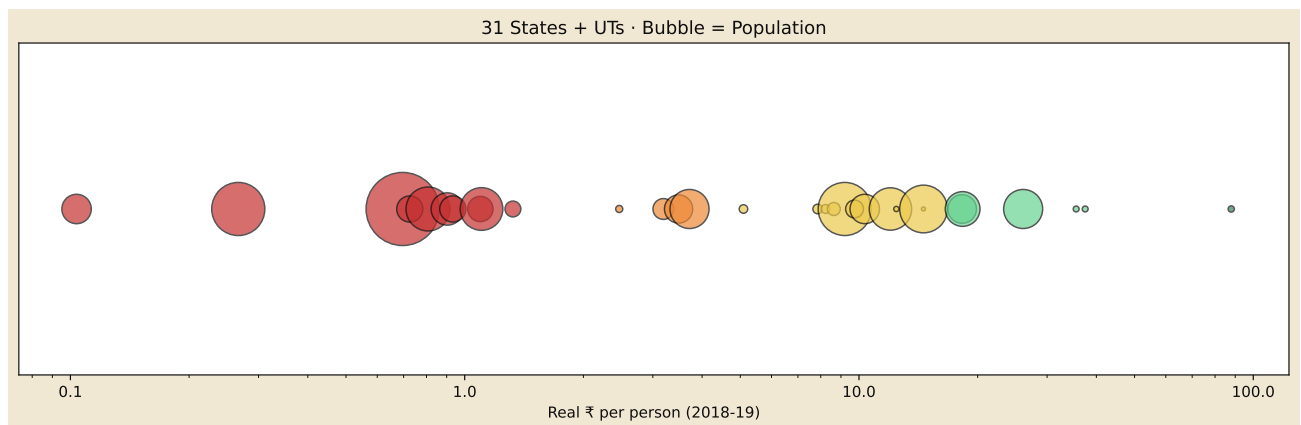


Figure 2: 31 Indian states by per-capita library expenditure 2018-19. Bubble size = Population.

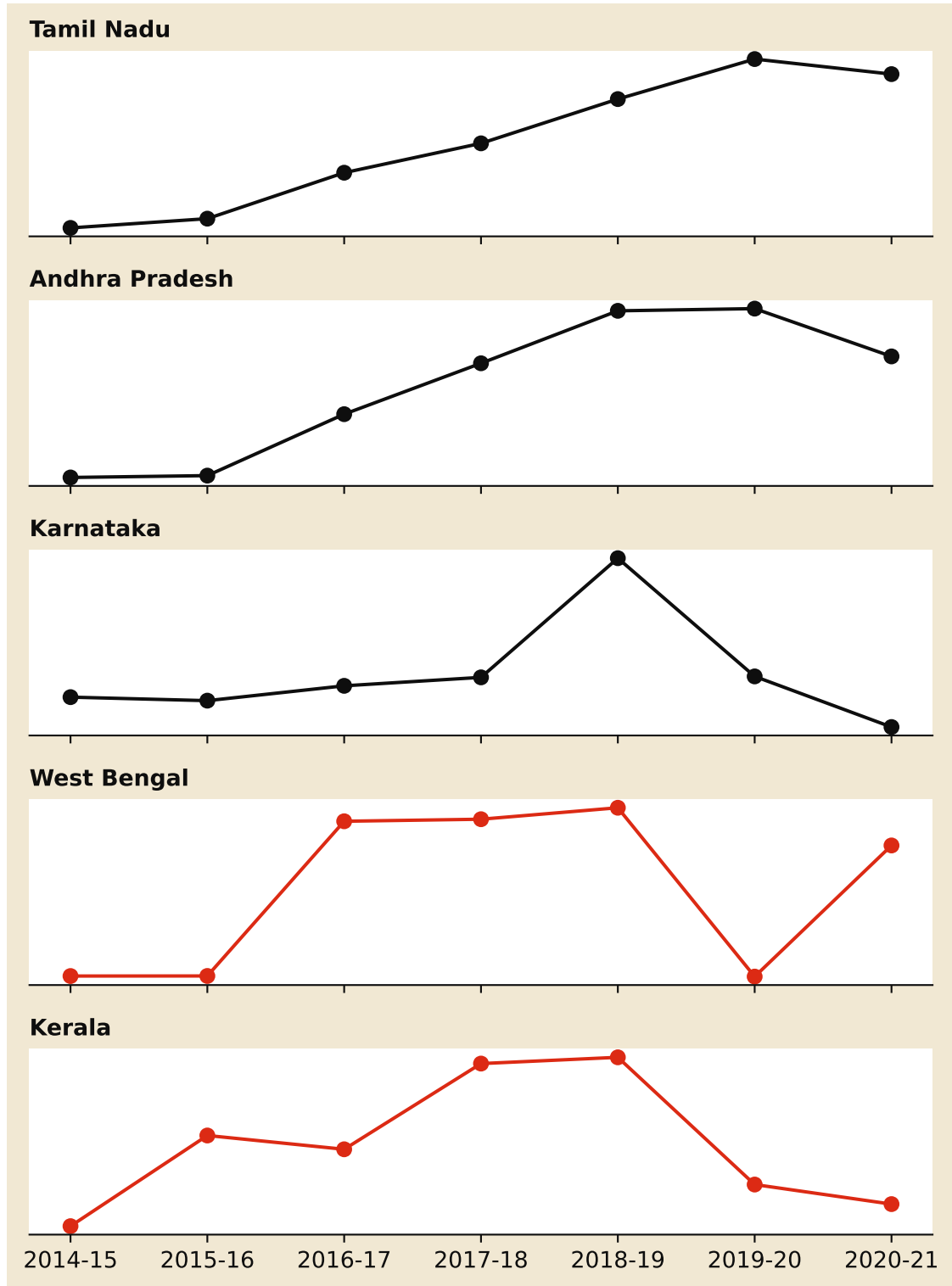


Figure 3: Expenditure volatility in cess states.

CENTRAL ZONAL COUNCIL

Every single state spends less than **2 per Indian per year** on public libraries. Over a quarter of India lives here.

- **Uttar Pradesh:** 0.70
- **Madhya Pradesh:** 0.81
- **Chhattisgarh:** 0.93
- **Uttarakhand:** 1.33

Section 6 · the legal architecture

Spending is downstream of legislation. India has had three generations of state library legislation — and 76 years into the Republic, a fourth group: **16 states, ~700 million people, no library law at all.**

Sources & Methodology

All real-terms per-capita figures on this page are deflated using the **MoSPI implicit GDP deflator** (base 2011-12).

1. Kulkarni, Balaji & Dhanamjaya (2025)
2. MoHFW Technical Group (2020)
3. Open Budgets India
4. MoSPI National Accounts Statistics

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